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History Revisited

For Indians, these heritage destinations are not relics, they are places of wonder and comfort



SUMEET INDER SINGH

Lucknow

For me, the skyline of Lucknow represents India, because you see minarets and mosques and temples and churches. It's a mixture of cultures and cuisines as well. Although I don't like decadence personally, it is nice to savour it for a short while. The Qaiser Bagh area in Lucknow is special for me. I have stayed there with my friends Meera and Muzaffar Ali. It's the epitome of *tehzeeb*, all sepia photographs and chandeliers and fine *kilims*; and it's deliciously slow-paced–all the way to the parterres of fragrant Sulaimani roses in Kotwara.

Srinagar

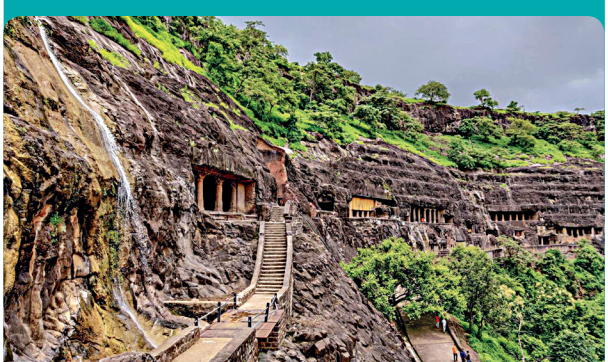
Srinagar was part of my childhood because we used to pass it on our way to Gulmarg, eating at Ahdoos and taking siestas in the shikara while our car was serviced. For the traveller to India, it is Switzerland with a lot of hustle and bustle. In the old parts, it could be a *kasbah* in Morocco. One lasting experience is the lake. Here we have a composite culture, mirrored in a lake. We don't have too many water cultures in India, which is why Srinagar should be celebrated. The wooden architecture is extraordinary.



I think the long winters, which produce the most exquisitely embellished crafts, have something to do with it. The geometric Khatambandh work of Turkish inspiration on the houseboat ceilings is wonderful.

Ajanta and Ellora

Instead of the Taj Mahal, the one symbol of India should be Ajanta and Ellora. It's up there in world heritage–perhaps even Number One. At Ellora, 400,000 tonnes of stone was hand-chipped over 800 years to create these rock-cut temples. People don't market it or tell enough of its story. The quietude of the arrival at Ajanta is amazing. They have now worked on it to create a decent visitor experience with tourist facilities–which is a relief.



Jodhpur

Jodhpur is wonderful because it has a great sense of arrival. If you fly in, you look down and see this absolutely dry landscape in summer, all brown colours and dust. It's like a moonscape; and then you see this tiny waterbody and the Umaid Bhawan Palace in the skyline as you land. It's a place where there are discoveries at every corner. It is India that is modern but also traditional. This is well represented by the erstwhile ruler, Maharaja Gaj Singh, fondly called Bapji, who is old-world and totally contemporary at the same time. The city has also grown in that direction. You can eat modern food here, stay in modern hotels, but you can also do the old-world. That mixture makes it a very Indian sort of civilised experience. Then there's the Mehrangarh Fort. What they've done with it is wonderful. You get a taste of royalty without being made envious of it. The whole experience they have created there is very well done.



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